The SLV-3 launch schedule was dependent on the arrival and integration of this equipment. On landing at the Madras airport, the aircraft which Sivakami was travel ing in skidded and overshot the runway. Dense smoke engulfed the aircraft. Everyone jumped out of the aircraft through emergency exits, and desperately fought to save themselves—al except Sivakami, who stayed in the aircraft til he removed the transponder from his baggage. He was among the last few persons, the others being mostly aircraft crew, to emerge from the smoke and he was hugging the transponder close to his chest.

Another incident from those days that I recal clearly relates to Prof. Dhawan's visit to the SLV-3 assembly building. Prof. Dhawan, Madhavan Nair and I were discussing some finer aspects of the SLV-3 integration. The vehicle was kept on the launcher in a horizontal position. When we were moving around and examining the readiness of the integrated hardware, I noticed the presence of big water-ports for extinguishing fire in case of an accident. For some reason, I felt uncomfortable at the sight of the ports facing the SLV-3 on the launcher. I suggested to Madhavan Nair that we could rotate the port